

6. Attention & Learning

Objective terms for describing how a child engages, focuses, and approaches learning.

Focus on observable behavior — how long, how often, under what conditions. Avoid 'can't focus' or 'doesn't try.' Describe what you see.

Engagement & Focus — Describe Duration and Conditions		
sustained attention for ____ minutes during ____	looked at materials for ____ seconds before ____	maintained focus with adult seated nearby
maintained focus when visual distractions were reduced	maintained focus with preferred materials	disengaged after ____ minutes
required a refocus prompt every ____ minutes	re-engaged within ____ seconds of prompt	remained on task for entire ____ minute activity
shifted attention when a peer entered the area	looked up from task when noise increased	watched peers before beginning the task
glanced around the room frequently during ____		

Task Initiation & Completion		
began the task independently within ____ seconds	began the task after one verbal prompt	began the task after a visual or physical cue
required repeated prompting to begin	completed the task independently	completed ____ out of ____ steps independently
stopped at step ____ and required support to continue	did not complete the task during the allotted time	requested a break after ____ minutes
returned to task after break and completed it	transitioned to a new task when directed	persisted through difficulty before seeking help
asked for help after ____ attempts		

Learning Approaches — How the Child Engages		
tried multiple approaches before succeeding	watched a peer model before attempting	responded well to visual demonstrations
responded well to verbal step-by-step instructions	worked best in a small group of ____	worked best one-to-one with an adult
preferred to work independently	asked clarifying questions before starting	preferred hands-on or movement-based activities
showed interest in books and print materials	engaged most with open-ended creative activities	transferred a skill learned in one setting to another
required repeated practice across ____ days to master		

Memory & Retention (Observable Behaviors)		
recalled the routine without a visual schedule	required a visual schedule to navigate the routine	remembered the activity from the previous day
did not appear to recall previous instruction on ____	generalized the skill to a new adult	generalized the skill to a new setting
applied the skill consistently across ____ days	required a re-teach after a long weekend or break	